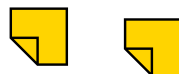


ARTICLE

Attitudes toward artificial intelligence (AI) and globalization: Common microfoundations and political implications

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Abstract

Advances in artificial intelligence (AI) are reshaping labor markets and sparking political debates. Like economic globalization, AI developments promise benefits, including job creation and lower prices, but also costs such as job displacement, raising crucial questions about public perceptions. Will AI, like globalization, challenge existing paradigms and trigger a backlash? Leveraging a conjoint experiment with 6,000 respondents from the United States and Canada, we examine public opinion toward offshoring and generative AI, focusing on the multidimensional trade-offs between job and price changes. Across all scenarios, respondents are equally or more sensitive to price changes than employment shifts. AI is favored over offshoring, especially among Democrats, highlighting an emerging partisan divide in the United States. Republicans and Canadians show more varied support, indicating AI is not immune to opposition. By focusing on the microfoundations of opinion formation, we identify scenarios that may trigger or temper protectionist stances.

Today, artificial intelligence (AI) and globalization are twin forces of change with profound implications for democracies. Both transformations produce complex, multidimensional economic effects, simultaneously influencing key aspects of the economy such as employment, productivity, and prices. Historically, the relationship between global capitalism and democratic institutions has been a source of tension, often characterized by “creative destruction” and disruptive distributive effects (Schumpeter, 1942). As economic security declines and inequality rises in the wake of these shifts, public support for these economic transformations and, by extension, for democratic governance itself, can erode. Democratic governments have responded with progressive taxation, social wel-

fare programs, and controls on the free movement of people, goods, and services. However, in an era characterized by the unprecedented openness of global markets, there is growing concern that these traditional mechanisms may be inadequate (Milner, 2021).

The advent of AI intensifies these concerns, as it challenges existing economic and political paradigms in the same way as globalization. AI is positioned to become a major disruptor of labor markets, particularly in advanced economies, raising questions about whether it will replicate the societal impacts of globalization. Much like globalization, AI has the potential to undermine public support for its deployment and, in turn, for democratic governance. As with past economic transformations, a backlash against AI could

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The Cornell Center for Social Sciences verified that the data and replication code submitted to the AJPS Dataverse replicates the numerical results reported in the main text of this article.

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fuel the rise of political parties that challenge the status quo and advocate for protectionist or exclusionary policies.

This study investigates the common microfoundations of public attitudes toward two paradigm-shifting phenomena: AI and globalization, and more specifically, generative AI and offshoring. By examining the multidimensional trade-offs inherent in these shocks—such as job creation, displacement, productivity increases, and price changes—we determine whether public responses to AI resemble those seen in response to globalization or follow unique patterns due to AI's novel nature. We also explore the potential political implications of AI, such as how political parties might choose to frame the economic consequences of this emerging technology, by examining how partisanship shapes people's support for AI under different scenarios.

Using a pre-registered conjoint survey experiment with approximately 6,000 respondents from the United States and Canada, we examine various scenarios that reflect the real-world implications of these economic shocks at the firm level. These scenarios span different job types, their potential for job creation or loss, and fluctuations in consumer prices, providing a comprehensive view of how the public perceives these shifts. This multidimensional framework allows us to move beyond the traditional focus on job losses alone, instead considering how individuals navigate the broader impacts of these transformations as both workers and consumers.

To date, much of the public debate on economic shocks has centered on job loss as the dominant factor shaping attitudes toward globalization and technological change.¹ While job displacement is a critical component, it offers a partial view. Both offshoring and AI introduce broader economic effects, including productivity gains and price reductions, which may benefit consumers even as certain jobs are lost. Yet, these trade-offs remain under-explored in political behavior research on economic shocks. This study seeks to fill that gap by examining how shifts in both employment and prices jointly influence public attitudes.

Will the multidimensional economic changes triggered by AI generate similar reactions to offshoring among the public? **Economists largely agree that the decline in US manufacturing jobs has been driven more by automation than by trade (Hicks & Devaraj, 2017; Irwin, 2016).** However, political rhetoric on both the right and left tends to attribute job loss more heav-

ily to trade than to automation, amplifying the salience of offshoring in political discourse (Mutz, 2021). As a result, AI and automation have not yet become issues distinctly owned by either political camp (Gallego & Kurer, 2022; Petrocik, 1996), whereas offshoring and trade have been more central to media and political discussions about job loss. Even as voters' attitudes toward globalization have remained relatively stable, issues related to trade have become increasingly politicized, with rising negativity surrounding the topic (Walter, 2021). Political parties have capitalized on this discontent, crafting policies that resonate with those disillusioned by globalization, resulting in a more polarized debate (Walter, 2021). This trend, however, has yet to develop around technology or AI, which has been less prominent in political discourse and largely absent from explicit party platforms or comprehensive policies (Rodrik, 2018). This presents an opportune moment to explore whether the microfoundations of attitudes toward AI mirror those toward globalization, and what political implications may arise as AI becomes more widely adopted.

Our study addresses these questions by examining public attitudes toward AI and offshoring through detailed scenarios that reflect the real-world economic changes that companies face. By incorporating both job and price shifts, we move beyond the dominant focus on job loss in previous research, providing a more comprehensive understanding of how the public evaluates these economic transformations. How individuals perceive these developments—whether as workers affected by job shifts or as consumers influenced by price changes—can significantly shape their support or opposition (Baker, 2003; Naoi & Kume, 2015). This deeper analysis of people's multidimensional preferences is important for identifying the conditions under which individuals will support or oppose these shifts, offering insights that can help politicians and policymakers gauge the factors that might promote or hinder the advancement of AI and globalization policies.

To answer these questions, we use a conjoint experiment embedded in a survey of approximately 3,000 US and 3,000 Canadian respondents, conducted in November 2023 by YouGov. Respondents were randomly assigned to either an offshoring or generative AI condition and were provided with a definition of the focal phenomenon. They were then shown a series of randomized scenarios describing how a company, either through offshoring or AI adoption, aimed to reduce production costs and potentially lower prices, while simultaneously causing job gains or losses. Respondents evaluated four distinct tables (from a possible 81 combinations) showing varying changes in prices and job levels across roles such as customer service, factory work, and data science. After viewing each table, respondents were asked to indicate their level of

¹ For some examples, see Anelli et al. (2019), Borwein, Bonikowski, et al. (2024), Borwein, Magistro, et al. (2024), Di Tella and Rodrik (2020), Frey and Osborne (2017), Gallego and Kurer (2022), Jeffrey and Matakos (2021), Jeffrey (2021), Mutz (2021), Werfel et al. (2022), and Wu (2023). For an exception, see Magistro et al. (2024), who consider the effects of more comprehensive information in the context of automation.

support for the company's decision to offshore jobs or adopt AI.

Our analysis proceeds in two steps. First, we use conjoint analysis to examine respondents' attitudes toward various trade-off scenarios for AI and offshoring at the aggregate level. Second, we explore how partisanship shapes responses to these shocks, examining whether supporters of right-wing and left-wing parties in each country respond differently to changes in prices and employment levels as a result of AI and offshoring. Although partisan alignments concerning free trade and offshoring have changed in the United States, as Republicans have become increasingly anti-trade since the early 2000s, AI has yet to be captured by any political party (Gallego & Kurer, 2022), making it more vulnerable to political framing and maneuvering.

While people are, on average, more supportive of generative AI than offshoring at the aggregate level, our findings reveal a pivotal insight: economic impacts from offshoring and AI—be it job shifts or price changes—elicit strong responses among voters, cutting across political boundaries. People are as responsive or more responsive to price changes than they are to employment changes, similarly for offshoring and AI; furthermore, they are always more sensitive to job losses than job gains. The observed responsiveness to price changes suggests that consumer interests could be a compelling factor in shaping public attitudes toward AI and offshoring, sometimes even outweighing employment concerns.

To illustrate the importance of these findings, we compare best-case and worst-case scenarios by adjusting both price and employment changes, demonstrating the substantial effect these real-world scenarios have on shaping public opinion. A shift from worst-case to best-case scenarios can increase support for AI and offshoring by 36% and 34%, respectively. More importantly, it can move people from weak opposition to weak support for both offshoring and AI, which can be substantially consequential politically.

While there is overall greater enthusiasm for AI than offshoring, this does not suggest AI is immune to opposition. US Democrats consistently emerge as AI optimists, maintaining support above neutral in all scenarios. In contrast, Republicans and Canadians express more caution, particularly under negative conditions, highlighting the potential for resistance to AI in specific contexts. For offshoring, as predicted, Democrats and Canadians are more supportive, while Republicans demonstrate a nuanced response, becoming more supportive with positive economic news. Importantly, Republicans demonstrate responsiveness to positive outcomes in the offshoring scenarios, suggesting that their attitudes are not as uniformly negative as might be expected given the polarized discourse surrounding the issue. In conclusion, different real-world scenarios can deeply

impact public support, indicating that attitudes can shift from opposition to support depending on the scenario presented.

The significant influence of price changes in shaping public opinion highlights an often overlooked factor in policy debates. While job losses and employment shifts are critical and emotionally charged, the direct benefits of lower consumer goods prices resonate widely across diverse demographics. This suggests that some individuals may prioritize their roles as consumers over their roles as workers when assessing economic changes. Politicians could leverage this insight by emphasizing consumer benefits, such as reduced prices, to mitigate opposition to economic transformations. Conversely, focusing on the risks of job displacement or downplaying potential price reductions could fuel resistance. Strategic framing of the impacts of AI and offshoring—whether highlighting consumer gains or employment risks—could significantly influence public perceptions and sway support or opposition. This is particularly relevant for AI, which, unlike offshoring, has not yet become a highly politicized issue, making it susceptible to political maneuvering.

Our study's results also underscore the broader political implications of these economic transformations. In the United States, Democrats' strong support for AI reflects an alignment with constituencies that typically benefit from technological advancements— younger, more educated, urban voters. This dynamic may further exacerbate the divide between economic winners and losers, a pattern already evident in the context of globalization. Without proactive measures to assist those negatively impacted by technological shifts, policymakers risk fueling a backlash against AI and related innovations. The lessons of globalization are clear: to prevent political backlash, leaders must address the distributional consequences of these transformations, ensuring support for those left behind by technological change.

THEORY

The multidimensional economic consequences of offshoring and AI

Our theory centers on the multidimensional nature of economic shocks, such as offshoring and AI adoption, which have simultaneous effects across economic dimensions, including employment, prices, and productivity. By integrating both offshoring and AI within a unified framework, we demonstrate how these shocks produce a range of potentially comparable outcomes, both positive (e.g., productivity gains, lower prices) and negative (e.g., job displacement). These effects are influenced by firm characteristics, industry structure, and market conditions. The complexity

of these varied outcomes creates significant trade-offs for workers, firms, and consumers, which we examine through our conjoint experiment. This approach allows us to investigate how individuals respond to different trade-offs, particularly between employment impacts and price changes.²

Offshoring refers to the relocation of a company's processes or services overseas, typically to reduce production costs or access new markets. AI involves adopting new technologies that are able to perform tasks that normally require human intelligence, such as learning, reasoning, problem-solving, perception, and language understanding. At the firm level, both offshoring and AI adoption can lead to changes in production processes that affect costs, prices, and employment. When a firm decides to offshore its operations or implement AI technologies, it can experience increased productivity due to reduced input costs or enhanced efficiency. This can shift the supply curve outward, potentially leading to lower prices for consumers. However, the extent to which these lower costs translate into lower prices and increased demand depends on market conditions, such as the level of competition and the price elasticity of demand for the firm's products.³

In perfectly competitive markets, we would expect that increased productivity from offshoring or AI adoption would lead to lower prices, stimulating demand if the price elasticity of demand is sufficiently high. This increase in demand could lead firms to expand production, potentially resulting in net job growth—the scale effect. However, substitution effects may also occur: Offshoring or AI might replace certain jobs, reducing the demand for domestic workers or those whose tasks can be automated.

The overall employment impact depends on the balance between these substitution and scale effects. If substitution effects dominate, net job losses may result. Conversely, if scale effects prevail, net job gains are possible. These effects are likely to vary across different types of workers. For example, workers whose tasks complement AI or involve managing offshore operations may benefit, while those performing routine, easily automated tasks may be at risk.

Similarly, offshoring may shift domestic employment toward higher-skilled, technology-driven roles while displacing lower-skill jobs.

Market structure further complicates this balance. In monopolistic or highly concentrated markets, firms may not pass on cost savings from offshoring or AI adoption to consumers in the form of lower prices. Instead, they might increase their markups, leading to higher profits without stimulating demand and production. This reduces the likelihood that scale effects will offset substitution effects, resulting in net job losses. Even in competitive markets, if only a few superstar firms successfully adopt offshoring or AI technologies, they may gain significant market power, set higher markups, and not necessarily lower prices.

Differences in firm productivity can also lead to heterogeneous outcomes within the same industry. Superstar firms that are more efficient at adopting offshoring or AI technologies may expand and hire more workers, while less productive firms may struggle, potentially leading to job losses or even exit from the market. This dynamic can result in a reallocation of employment within the industry, with varying effects on different types of workers.

Empirical evidence suggests that the impact of offshoring and AI adoption on employment is mixed and context-dependent.⁴ Our goal in this study is to highlight the multidimensional nature of economic shocks like offshoring and AI adoption. As detailed, these transformations produce a complex array of outcomes across different dimensions—such as employment, prices, and productivity—which can lead to divergent consequences for various industries, firms, and workers. By constructing scenarios that capture this range of possibilities, we explore how individuals navigate the trade-offs between job gains or losses and price changes. This multidimensional approach provides a more comprehensive understanding of how economic transformations like offshoring and AI affect workers and consumers alike, enabling us to assess their broader economic impacts.

² While our comparison of AI and offshoring focuses primarily on their economic consequences—such as job displacement, productivity gains, and price changes—and the potential for political mobilization around these issues, we recognize that AI also brings regulatory concerns that differ from those associated with globalization. Issues like intellectual property, data privacy, discrimination, and algorithmic transparency are central to AI regulation. However, these regulatory aspects are beyond the scope of this paper.

³ The price elasticity of demand measures the responsiveness of the quantity demanded of a good to a change in its price. A higher elasticity indicates that consumers are more sensitive to price changes, with values greater than one indicating elastic demand, values less than one indicating inelastic demand, and a value of one representing unit elasticity. Elastic demand means consumers significantly reduce their demand or increase it in response to price changes, whereas inelastic demand means consumers' purchasing behavior changes little with price adjustments.

⁴ Empirical studies on offshoring largely show that its impact on domestic employment is limited, as detailed by Görg (2011), although effects differ by skill level, adversely affecting low-skilled workers while benefiting high-skilled ones (Hummels et al., 2014). Kovak et al. (2017) observe that while employment may decline in certain firms due to offshoring, it often increases in others, resulting in a slight net positive impact on US employment despite significant job displacement and worker reallocation. The Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD)'s Employment Outlook (OECD, 2007) suggests that offshoring can have neutral or positive effects on sectoral employment. It indicates that while offshoring displaces some jobs, it also generates new ones by enhancing firm competitiveness and expanding production scales. Nonetheless, the skills required for newly created jobs often differ from those lost. Similarly, studies on AI adoption indicate that AI could be used not only to replace or complement what workers do but could also create new jobs, hence it is not known exactly which or how many jobs are at risk (Acemoglu & Restrepo, 2019; Agrawal et al., 2019).

Public support for offshoring and AI

Much of the existing research on public support for economic shocks centers on labor market risks, particularly job losses, as the primary factor shaping attitudes toward these transformations (Anelli et al., 2019; Borwein, Bonikowski, et al., 2024; Borwein, Magistro, et al., 2024; Di Tella & Rodrik, 2020; Frey & Osborne, 2017; Gallego & Kurer, 2022; Jeffrey & Matakos, 2021; Jeffrey, 2021; Mutz, 2021; Werfel et al., 2022; Wu, 2023). While this perspective highlights an important dimension, it oversimplifies the broader economic trade-offs, which include price reductions, productivity gains, and employment shifts across sectors and firms. Understanding how individuals assess these multidimensional effects is critical for evaluating public support for these economic transformations.

Building on this multidimensional framework, we argue that offshoring and AI affect a broad range of outcomes—employment, prices, and productivity—but individuals' attitudes toward these shocks are shaped by the limited information available to them. Despite the complex trade-offs involved, people frequently lack a comprehensive understanding of how these shocks impact them personally or the national economy. This is primarily because they are rarely exposed to balanced, objective cost–benefit information about these phenomena. Instead, the public tends to focus on certain aspects—particularly job losses—due to three main factors: misattribution, negative framing, and a disproportionate focus on employment rather than prices by politicians and the media.

Research shows that people often misattribute job losses to globalization, underestimating the significant role of technology in driving job polarization and economic inequality. In advanced economies, the concurrence of deindustrialization and increasing income inequality with heightened global trade and migration have led many to believe that de-globalization would reverse these structural trends (Milner, 2021; Wu, 2023). However, despite these beliefs to the contrary, evidence suggests a much smaller impact of trade on job losses as compared to automation (Di Tella & Rodrik, 2020; Hicks & Devaraj, 2017; Irwin, 2016). While manufacturing job loss linked to free trade was a major topic in the 2016 US presidential election, technology has been, and will continue to be, a more significant factor across sectors. Research by Acemoglu and Restrepo (2020) highlights the significant negative impact of robotics on employment and wages, while Frey and Osborne (2017) predicted that nearly half of American jobs could be at risk from new technological advancements. Furthermore, the impact of emerging generative AI technologies on productivity, job displacement, and job creation remains to be fully assessed. Unlike earlier automation technologies that mainly affected routine tasks,

these new forms of AI hold the potential to both enhance and replace labor in a broader range of high-skilled, non-routine cognitive roles, including software development, content creation, and design (Brynjolfsson et al., 2023). In sum, the evidence suggests that people may have misattributed job losses to globalization rather than technological change, further distorting public perceptions of these economic transformations.

Second, political elites and the media play a crucial role in shaping public perceptions. Rather than providing balanced information, they often emphasize the negative aspects—such as job displacement and economic insecurity—while downplaying or ignoring potential benefits like job creation, increased productivity, and lower consumer prices. This selective framing is more effective in riling political emotions and mobilizing support, but it also skews public sentiment against these economic changes. Despite technological change being a key contributor to increasing inequality and job polarization, contemporary political parties seldom mobilize voters against such changes, opting instead to attribute labor market shifts to trade and immigration, thereby stoking out-group resentments (Gallego & Kurer, 2022; Mutz, 2021; Wu, 2022). This framing leverages attribution theory and intergroup conflict theories, suggesting that attributing job loss to foreigners rather than technology stirs stronger emotional responses and out-group antagonism, making it a potent narrative for political mobilization (Bobo & Hutchings, 1996; Mutz, 2021). Media coverage further amplifies this dynamic, with negative news about trade and job losses outweighing positive coverage of economic benefits like lower prices (Margalit, 2011; Guisinger, 2017; Soroka, 2006). Automation and technological change, despite their potential for job creation, are similarly portrayed as threats to employment (Anelli et al., 2019; Frey & Osborne, 2017; Im et al., 2019). This emphasis on the negative impacts likely fuels public opposition to both phenomena (Di Tella & Rodrik, 2020; Dür, 2019; Gallego et al., 2021; Jeffrey & Matakos, 2021; Mutz, 2021; Rodrik, 2018; Werfel et al., 2022).

The focus on employment effects is not just a feature of political actors and the media (Margalit, 2011; Guisinger, 2017; Soroka, 2006); it is also reinforced by the academic literature. Most research on attitudes toward automation and trade measure respondents' self-interest solely using their employment status rather than their status as consumers (Baker, 2003, 2005; Helpman, 2011). However, people navigate dual identities as both workers and consumers, and which identity is more salient can shift depending on external factors like media framing or political messaging (Naoi & Kume, 2015). While in some contexts, people may be primed to prioritize employment effects due to job security concerns, there are compelling reasons

to believe that price changes may also significantly influence public attitudes.

Price changes, unlike employment effects, affect everyone as consumers, directly influencing their purchasing power and daily economic well-being. For example, lower prices resulting from productivity gains could benefit a wider range of individuals, even in sectors experiencing job losses. Evidence from Japan's 2007–2009 financial crisis shows that large consumer benefits, such as lower prices, can lead individuals—especially those from lower-income groups—to prioritize their roles as consumers over their concerns as workers, even in difficult economic times (Naoi & Kume, 2015). This duality suggests that citizens' responses to economic shocks are not monolithic but depend on which aspect of their economic identity—consumer or worker—is activated in a given moment. Additionally, given that price effects have received far less media attention, compared to job and wage impacts, this novelty might make respondents more likely to focus on price changes when presented with them.

By presenting respondents simultaneously with information about both price and employment effects, we aim to capture how people balance these competing dimensions of economic shocks. Our study simulates real-world decision-making, where individuals must weigh multiple trade-offs between their roles as both consumers and workers. The evidence is mixed on whether people prioritize their position as producers or consumers in evaluating trade (Alfaro et al., 2022; Chatruc et al., 2021; Hiscox, 2006; Naoi & Kume, 2015; Stantcheva, 2022). However, in the context of automation, Magistro et al. (2024) find that respondents are more responsive to prices than employment changes.

To examine the microfoundations of public attitudes toward AI and globalization, we design scenarios that present individuals with various potential outcomes, such as shifts in consumer prices and changes in employment levels across job types. This allows us to capture the multidimensional nature of these economic shocks and explore how individuals weigh trade-offs at the aggregate level.

In light of the preceding discussion, we make several predictions:

H1. *Given the low general awareness of the multidimensional impacts of AI and offshoring, we anticipate that:*

- Respondents will show greater support for scenarios where gains exceed losses;
- Respondents will exhibit a stronger response to changes in prices than to changes in employment numbers.

H2. *Respondents will show greater support for AI over offshoring.*

H3. *Respondents exposed to offshoring scenarios will react more negatively to job losses and show muted responses to job gains and price reductions compared to those presented with AI scenarios.*

The political consequences of economic shocks

The political consequences of economic transformations, such as AI and offshoring, depend not only on the economic disruption they cause but also on how political actors frame these disruptions. As discussed previously, AI and globalization introduce widespread economic changes, impacting multiple sectors, industries, and workers. Economically, AI mirrors the effects of globalization, potentially leading to job displacement, productivity gains, and price changes. Importantly, while technological change has caused more job losses in manufacturing than trade, voters often struggle to distinguish between the labor market effects of automation and globalization (Gallego & Kurer, 2022). This conflation suggests that voters may not differentiate between these sources of economic disruption (Mutz, 2021; Rodrik, 2018; Wu, 2022).

While AI and globalization share similar economic effects, what about their political consequences? The potential for political realignment resulting from labor market disruptions makes globalization an especially apt comparison for AI, given the politicization of globalization and its role in fueling populism (Colantone & Stanig, 2018; Rodrik, 2021; Scheiring et al., 2024). Although earlier waves of technological change, such as computerization or automation, disrupted labor markets, AI represents a distinct transformation. Unlike past advances that primarily affected routine and manual tasks, generative AI is poised to impact both high-skill, non-routine cognitive jobs as well as lower-skilled work (Acemoglu & Restrepo, 2020; Brynjolfsson et al., 2023; Frey & Osborne, 2017). This broader potential for job displacement makes AI a more unpredictable and far-reaching economic force. Furthermore, what differentiates the current political climate from the 1990s is that parties today are far more aware of the precedent set by the politicization of trade, particularly the rise of populist backlash. This has made them more sensitive to the potential political ramifications of large-scale economic disruptions like AI. Additionally, political polarization has reached unprecedented levels, meaning that any new economic shock is far more likely to be weaponized for partisan contestation than in previous decades. This political environment makes AI much more

vulnerable to becoming a politically charged issue, similar to how globalization was in the past, and this is why globalization—rather than earlier technological changes like the computer or internet revolution—is a relevant comparison point for understanding the potential political consequences of AI's disruption.

Though AI has not yet been politicized to the same extent as globalization, this may change as its economic consequences become more apparent (Gallego & Kurer, 2022; König & Wenzelburger, 2018).⁵ Political parties may eventually mobilize around AI, framing it as either a threat or an opportunity, much like they did with globalization. Globalization, too, was not immediately politicized; it took years for political entrepreneurs to capitalize on the labor market disruptions it caused (Walter, 2021). This potential for future politicization makes the comparison to globalization relevant, as the backlash against globalization has driven the rise of populist radical-right parties. Economic disruptions, particularly those intensifying labor market competition, have triggered political realignments grounded in grievance and resentment (Rodrik, 2021; Scheiring et al., 2024). Thus, the political consequences of AI could follow a similar trajectory.

Globalization is more likely than AI to evoke strong in-group versus out-group distinctions, as it involves easily identifiable external actors—foreign countries or immigrants—who can be blamed for domestic job losses. As a result, the nationalist and exclusionary rhetoric of populist-right parties may resonate more strongly with workers affected by globalization than by technological advancements (Mutz, 2021). Nonetheless, concerns over technological change can also heighten anti-immigrant sentiments by exacerbating feelings of economic competition with immigrant workers. For instance, when workers are informed about the potential negative employment effects of technological advancements, they may become more inclined to support restrictive trade policies and anti-immigrant positions (Di Tella & Rodrik, 2020; Gamez-Djokic & Waytz, 2020). Populist-right parties may capitalize on broader anxieties about economic decline, redirecting these concerns toward more salient targets of blame, such as trade or immigration, rather than focusing directly on technology (Gallego & Kurer, 2022; Mutz, 2021; Wu, 2022).

While voter attitudes toward globalization have not changed significantly over time, the issue has become increasingly politicized, with political actors activating latent concerns and grievances to mobilize support

around protectionist and populist platforms (Walter, 2021). This political dynamic is important because parties tend to activate and make salient attitudes to which people are already disposed (Bonikowski, 2017; Danieli et al., 2022). Structural changes like globalization or technological change can shift voter priorities, creating fertile ground for political actors to tap into preexisting anxieties (Danieli et al., 2022). By activating latent attitudes in response to shifting economic conditions, political parties can shape the public's political behavior, amplifying the salience of these issues (Bonikowski, 2017). This process of activation is likely to be crucial as AI's economic impacts become more apparent and parties begin to mobilize around its potential disruptions.

To further explore these political consequences, we examine partisan differences in support for offshoring and AI across countries. Partisanship plays a significant role in shaping policy preferences, affecting the information individuals receive and how they process it (Taber & Lodge, 2006; Zaller, 1992). In US politics, partisanship is a key identity that influences a wide array of political attitudes, preferences, and behaviors, including trust in government and economic evaluations (Bolsen et al., 2014; Lenz, 2013).

Given the transformative potential of AI and its broad implications for labor markets, it is essential to understand whether partisan identities will similarly influence attitudes toward AI. To date, AI has not been heavily politicized by any major political parties, leading to an expectation that supporters of right-wing and left-wing parties may not display significantly different attitudes toward AI or respond differently to information about it (Gallego & Kurer, 2022). This lack of politicization suggests that opinions on AI may still be malleable and subject to change as new information emerges or as political elites begin to frame AI in partisan terms. Should political elites engage with AI as a partisan issue, it could quickly become contentious, much like trade and immigration.

Regarding offshoring, there is already a well-established partisan divide, particularly in the United States. In Canada, free trade has become more of a non-issue, attracting near-unanimous support across the political spectrum, with no significant partisan differences in attitudes toward offshoring.⁶ This consensus suggests that offshoring and free trade are not contentious political issues in Canada, and we do not expect to find significant partisan differences in support for offshoring among Canadian respondents.

In contrast, the situation is markedly different in the United States. Historically, Republicans were strong proponents of free trade, but there has been a significant transformation within the party (Mutz, 2017; Wu, 2022). Growing discontent with globaliza-

⁵ Although AI has not yet reached the same level of political salience as offshoring and it still lacks clear partisan divides (Margalit & Raviv, 2023; Zhang & Dafoe, 2020), the rapid growth of regulatory frameworks, such as the Artificial Intelligence and Data Act in Canada and subnational proposals in California and Alberta, indicates that AI is quickly becoming a significant political issue. As AI's economic and social impacts become more visible, we expect political actors to increasingly engage with it, mirroring the gradual politicization seen in areas like globalization.

⁶ See <https://www.enviroinstitute.org/insights/insight-details/one-issue-on-which-canadians-aren't-polarized-the-u.s>.

tion among the Republican base, which predated the Trump administration, was amplified by Trump's "America First" rhetoric, leading to a more protectionist stance (Essig et al., 2021; Mutz, 2017). This shift suggests that Republicans may now show lower support for offshoring, compared to Democrats, and may be less responsive to positive information about offshoring's benefits.

The changes in the Republican stance on free trade highlight the changing nature of partisan attitudes and the potential for significant shifts in response to elite cues and changing political narratives. Given that AI shares many characteristics with globalization in terms of its disruptive potential, it is important to understand whether AI could trigger similar partisan divides and political realignments in the future. In this context, we hypothesize the following:

H4. *There will be no differences in support for AI or responsiveness to price or job changes among voters of right-wing or left-wing parties in the United States or Canada;*

H5. *In Canada, there will be no differences in support for offshoring or responsiveness to price or job changes among voters of right-wing or left-wing parties;*

H6. *In the United States, Republicans will be less supportive of offshoring than Democrats. They will also respond more negatively to job losses and show muted responses to job gains and price reductions relative to Democrats.*

RESEARCH DESIGN

To explore the microfoundations of attitudes toward AI and offshoring, we fielded a large-N preregistered conjoint survey experiment across the United States and Canada, two countries that have experienced similar patterns of labor market de-routinization alongside sharing similar welfare state institutions (De La Rica & Gortazar, 2016). Surveys serve as a crucial instrument for analyzing human perceptions, attitudes, reasoning, and opinions—which are often separate and may be distinct from revealed preferences and behaviors.

Importantly, our preregistered conjoint experiment manipulated the source of the economic shock. The Distinguishing between the labor market repercussions of technological change versus globalization remains a complex challenge (Gallego & Kurer, 2022). The interconnected nature of technological change and global trade further complicates this challenge, rendering it unrealistic to expect citizens to cleanly separate the two as sources of economic upheaval (Mutz, 2021; Rodrik, 2018; Wu, 2022).

Conjoint analysis, now a staple in political science research, facilitates a closer simulation of real-world decision-making by presenting participants with hypothetical scenarios comprising various attributes. Conjoint experiments have numerous benefits, primarily the ability to simultaneously assess the causal impact of multiple attributes on a single outcome and determine their relative significance, mirroring external decision-making processes that require individuals to weigh various trade-offs across several dimensions (Bansak et al., 2021b; Hainmueller et al., 2014). Other advantages include reducing biases related to social desirability (Bansak et al., 2021b), minimizing the risk of respondents "satisficing" (Bansak et al., 2021a), as well as having external validity (Hainmueller et al., 2015). Recent applications of conjoint designs span across evaluating political candidates, taxation preferences, and housing policies, showcasing the method's versatility (Leeper et al., 2020).

To test our predictions, we conducted twin surveys engaging 3,000 participants from the United States and an equal number from Canada, all recruited through the survey firm YouGov (Magistro et al., 2025). Our study protocol was preregistered with OSF at osf.io/y2m9b. YouGov's stratified sampling approach, informed by demographic variables such as age, race/ethnicity, gender, education, geographical location, and recent voting behavior, ensured a representative cross-section of respondents.⁷ The data collection and analysis procedures were reviewed by the Institutional Review Board at the California Institute of Technology and were ruled exempt (IR23-1355). They were also reviewed and approved by the University of British Columbia Office of Research Ethics (H23-03070).

Conjoint experiment

Participants were randomly assigned to scenarios depicting either an AI or offshoring economic shock, and they were then provided with a definition of either shock.

Generative AI refers to artificial intelligence systems that can be used, for example, to write computer code, automate production tasks, streamline operations, or provide customer service via chatbots. OR

Offshoring refers to the practice of relocating business activities, services, or jobs, ranging from production chain and customer service to software engineering, to another country.

⁷ See Table A1 in the Online Supporting Information for an overview of the sample demographics.

TABLE 1 Effects of artificial intelligence (AI)/offshoring on prices and jobs.

Attribute	Before	After	Change (absolute)	Change (%)
Price of smartphone	\$600	[\$600, \$450, \$300]	[\$0, −\$150, −\$300]	[0%, −25%, −50%]
Number of customer service jobs	100	[75, 100, 125]	[−25, 0, +25]	[−25%, 0%, +25%]
Number of factory jobs	400	[300, 400, 500]	[−100, 0, +100]	[−25%, 0%, +25%]
Number of computer/data science jobs	200	[150, 200, 250]	[−50, 0, +50]	[−25%, 0%, +25%]

Notes: This table summarizes the effects of AI and offshoring on key economic attributes in the conjoint experiment, presenting baseline values, potential changes, and corresponding percentages. Square brackets denote the prespecified set of possible attribute values.

Next, all respondents saw the following prompt (localized for each country and the respective shock):

A [US, Canadian] company producing smartphones is [offshoring some of its activities abroad / adopting new generative AI tools]. This change will decrease production costs, which could lead to lower product prices. However, while some jobs might be created, others might be lost. On the one hand, [offshoring/the new generative AI tools] could reduce the need for some workers as jobs are [relocated abroad/substituted by machines], possibly leading to job losses. On the other hand, [offshoring/the new generative AI tools] could lower production costs, making companies more productive and allowing them to charge lower prices. This could increase demand for their products, encouraging companies to expand production and hire more workers. These new jobs might require the same or different skills.

The following four tables display different possible scenarios, showing the changes in prices before and after a company [offshores some of its activities abroad / adopts new generative AI tools], as well as the number of employees in different roles within the company.⁸

⁸ These numbers are inherently subjective and context-dependent. Our selected values aim to reflect plausible scenarios that respondents can easily comprehend and evaluate. The chosen price reductions (up to 50%) and job changes (up to 25%) represent a spectrum of potential impacts. While a \$300 price reduction on a smartphone might seem modest compared to large-scale job losses, it can represent significant savings for individuals. Conversely, even smaller-scale job losses can have severe consequences for those directly affected. The diversity of the scenarios helps balance these differing perceptions and allows us to capture a broad range of public attitudes. Our approach is designed to simulate realistic variations within each dimension and to analyze how individuals weigh consumer benefits against job losses. While these job numbers are hypothetical, the Bureau of Labor Statistics provides information on occupational employment for each US industry. When looking at computer and electronic product manufacturing, it appears that Office and Administrative Support Occupations, of which customer service workers are part of, constitute 7.5% of the total jobs in the industry.

Then, each respondent saw four tables (see Table 1 for a list of all possible attribute values and Table 2 for an example of a table that a respondent would see), each with randomized numbers of gains and losses as a result of the respective shock. The randomized attributes included smartphone prices, customer service job numbers, factory job numbers, and data science/computer science job positions.^{9,10} To mitigate order biases and cognitive load, the presentation order of attributes within each table was randomized yet consistent for each respondent.

Finally, we asked the following question after each conjoint table (the question appeared on the same page as the table), using a 5-point scale from “*strongly oppose*” to “*strongly support*” (with a sixth “*don’t know*” option):

- Do you support the company’s decision to [offshore some of its activities abroad/ adopt new generative AI tools]?

Although our experiment centers on a fictional company’s decision to adopt AI or engage in offshoring within a single industry, aligning with common practice in the field, we acknowledge that our insights might not be generalizable. However, Magistro et al. (2024) examine the responses to four varied firms (involved in manufacturing smartphones, cars, airplanes, and vaccines), finding no significant industry-

Computer and Mathematical Occupations, of which computer scientists are part of constitute 13% of all jobs, while Production occupations, of which assembly and production factory workers are part of, constitute 28% of all jobs. These suggest that our proportions are in line with the industry. See https://www.bls.gov/oes/current/naics3_334000.htm.

⁹ One could argue that given the rising inequality and divide in wage growth across occupations and sectors, we could also have considered wages in addition to jobs. While this paper does not include wage information, in related work, Magistro et al. (2024) explore the effects of price, job, and wage changes in response to automation. They find that respondents are much more sensitive to price changes than either employment or wages and that they are responsive to wage losses but not wage gains.

¹⁰ The exclusion of price increases in our study reflects the nature of technological innovation, where real, quality-adjusted prices tend to decline over time, even as nominal prices may increase due to improvements in product quality. In other words, when products improve in quality through innovation, the actual cost to consumers—adjusted for these enhancements—effectively decreases, even if nominal prices rise. This suggests that our study’s focus on nominal prices without adjusting for quality likely underestimates the true impact on consumer perceptions, providing a conservative estimate of price sensitivity.

TABLE 2 Sample table presented to respondents during the conjoint experiment.

Attribute	Before	After	Change (absolute)	Change (%)
Price of smartphone	\$600	\$300	−\$300	−50%
Number of customer service jobs	100	100	0	0%
Number of factory jobs	400	500	+100	+25%
Number of computer/data science jobs	200	150	−50	−25%

Notes: This table illustrates a sample table displayed to respondents during one round of the conjoint experiment. The table describes a hypothetical scenario involving either offshoring or AI adoption by a company. Respondents were asked to evaluate the scenario based on changes in smartphone prices and employment levels across various job categories (e.g., customer service, factory, and data science roles). The values under the “After” column were randomized based on the entire set of possible values listed in Table 1.

level differences in attitudes toward automation. This suggests that our estimates likely transcend specific industry sectors.

In the Results section, we present figures of the marginal means (MMs), which are descriptive representations of conjoint data. MMs represent the average outcome for a given attribute level, across all appearances of that level, while averaging over all other attributes.¹¹ The causal average marginal component effects (AMCEs), shown in the Online Supporting Information, isolate the effect of a specific attribute level relative to a baseline category while holding all other attributes constant (Leeper et al., 2020). In fully randomized designs, AMCEs simply represent differences between MMs at each feature level and the MM in the reference category, ignoring other features (Leeper et al., 2020).

The decision to focus on MMs in the main results is driven by the objectives of our study. AMCEs are ideal for understanding the relative impact of specific attributes on respondent support—how much a particular attribute value boosts or diminishes support, compared to a baseline.

However, MMs provide a broader view by capturing overall support across all levels of an attribute without relying on a baseline or reference category. This is particularly useful when our goal is to understand absolute support levels across scenarios, such as how AI and offshoring are viewed overall, rather than merely the isolated effect of any single attribute.

Furthermore, MMs offer critical advantages over AMCEs, especially for subgroup analysis. MMs are robust to changes in the reference category, which makes them ideal for capturing absolute support levels across different subgroups (Leeper et al., 2020; Treger, 2023). Additionally, while AMCEs only show relative changes in support, MMs can reveal the extent to which respondents move from opposition to support,

offering richer descriptive insights into how people respond to policy issues like AI and offshoring. In all the analyses, standard errors are clustered on the respondent (Leeper et al., 2020).

RESULTS

Our analysis yields several key insights into public support for generative AI and offshoring. First, as predicted, across all attributes examined, there is a general preference for generative AI over offshoring. This trend is evident in Figure 1, which displays MMs of support for each economic shock.

Second, consistent with our expectations, people are responsive to both prices and employment numbers: a decrease in prices due to either economic shock increases support, while job losses (gains) lead to a decrease (increase) in support. Notably, people are as responsive or more responsive to prices than they are to employment changes, both for offshoring and for AI; furthermore, they are always more sensitive to job losses than job gains. While at first sight, it may appear that people are more sensitive to changes in factory jobs than other types of jobs, the number of jobs is different across different categories, and once we compute slopes (the changes in support divided by the changes in jobs), we see that in fact respondents are most responsive to customer service jobs.

Finally, Figure A1 in the Online Supporting Information shows us the AMCEs, which represent how much support for either shock would change on average if one attribute switched levels and their difference. Respondents do not appear to respond more negatively to job losses in offshoring than AI. Instead, none of the effects differ between AI and offshoring, suggesting that people respond similarly to changes in prices and employment that result from either shock, despite offshoring being more salient and politicized.^{12,13}

¹¹ Miratrix et al. (2018) argue that in survey experiments that use high-quality and representative samples, from firms such as YouGov, estimates of the sample average treatment effect (SATE) are typically adequate for the majority of research objectives. Table A1 in the Online Supporting Information confirms the representativeness of our sample. We also run our analyses with weights, and estimates of our SATEs show minimal variation from those using weights but have the added advantage of avoiding the reduction in statistical power that comes with weighting.

¹² In the Online Supporting Information, we show results conditional on passing a manipulation check, and these results are not substantively different than those reported here (see Figures E1–E4). We also show results by country in Figure B1 in the Online Supporting Information.

¹³ While our main analysis focuses on aggregate results, we conducted additional exploratory subgroup analyses in the Online Supporting Infor-

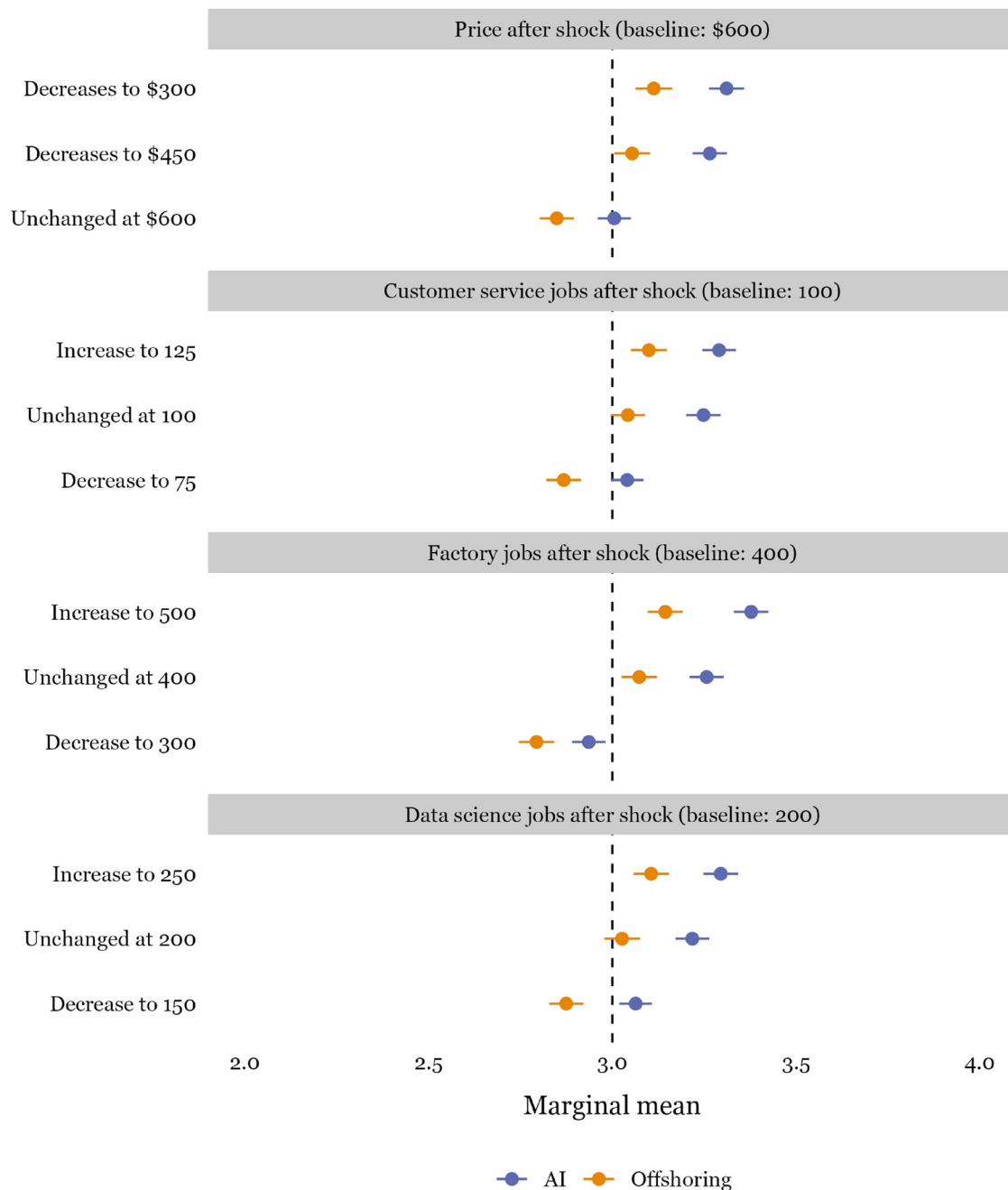


FIGURE 1 Marginal means (MMs) of support for artificial intelligence (AI) and offshoring. *Notes:* This figure displays MMs of support (1 *strongly oppose* to 5 *strongly support*) for AI and offshoring, along with 95% confidence intervals. The MMs illustrate the average outcome for each specific level of a conjoint attribute, averaging across all other attributes. Baselines represent attribute values before the economic shock.

To demonstrate the substantive importance of our findings, we now calculate predicted support for AI and offshoring by averaging across the top 10% of best-case scenarios, the middle 10% of scenarios, and the

bottom 10% of worst-case scenarios. As we can see in Figure 2, support for AI in the worst-case scenarios (bottom 10%) is 2.65 [95% CI: 2.46, 2.84], while support for offshoring is 2.53 [95% CI: 2.33, 2.72]. For the middle 10% of scenarios, support for AI is 3.20 [95% CI: 3.01, 3.38], and for offshoring, it is 3.01 [95% CI: 2.81, 3.21]. Finally, in the best-case scenarios (top 10%), support for AI is 3.60 [95% CI: 3.40, 3.81], while support for offshoring is 3.40 [95% CI: 3.19, 3.61].

information to investigate whether support for AI and offshoring varies by socio-demographic factors, such as age, gender, income, and education (our proxy for objective risk). These analyses revealed some variation in overall levels of support but found no significant differences in the effects (AMCEs) of price and job changes across most subgroups (see Figures F1–F4 in the Online Supporting Information).

This indicates that seeing a best-case relative to a worst-case scenario increases support for AI and offshoring, respectively, by 36% and 34%. More importantly, it can move people from weak opposition to weak support, which can be very consequential politically.

Results by party

Next, we turn to differences by partisanship.¹⁴ We start from the United States, where we focus on Democrats and Republicans (in the Online Supporting Information, we also include “Others,” which comprise Independents and people who do not identify with any parties).¹⁵ Figure 3 illustrates the MMs of support for AI by partisanship. What emerges is that while all respondents, regardless of party, are on average supportive of AI, Democrats are the most supportive group. Holding everything else constant, Republicans become neutral toward AI when they see scenarios that involve job losses or no price changes.

In terms of AMCEs, Figure A2 in the Online Supporting Information reveals that both Republicans and Democrats are similarly responsive to price changes, as their support for AI increases when prices decrease. Both groups are responsive to job losses among all job categories. Finally, results are more mixed in terms of responsiveness to job gains, where again respondents are not as responsive to job gains relative to job losses or price changes.

Figure 3 also shows MMs of support for offshoring by partisanship. Democrats are overall more supportive of offshoring than Republicans, though at lower levels than for AI, as predicted. However, contrary to our expectations, both Republican and Democratic respondents are equally responsive to the information that they see. While Republicans never cross the neutral line (3), they do move from opposed to neutral positions as a result of the different scenarios that they see. If anything, Republicans are slightly more responsive than Democrats to price changes as illustrated by Figure A3 in the Online Supporting Information. Both groups are responsive to job losses among all categories of workers, while when it comes to job gains respondents are not as sensitive to information.

Next, we look at Canada, where we focus on the three main parties: the center-left Liberal Party of Canada, the right-wing Conservative Party of Canada, and the left-wing New Democratic Party (NDP) (in Figure D2 in the Online Supporting Information, we also include “Others,” which comprise the Bloc Québécois, the Greens, the People’s Party of Canada, and people who do not identify with any parties. This group is however small and heterogeneous and as a result the estimates are imprecise). Figure 4 shows MMs of support for AI by partisanship. As predicted, support for AI is very similar across the three main parties in Canada.

While there is some variation in responsiveness to job gains, supporters of all parties respond similarly to price changes and job losses: As prices decline, their support for AI increases, while as jobs decrease, support for AI also decreases. The only significant difference in effects across parties is that NDP voters are more responsive to factory job gains and losses than supporters of the other two parties, as shown also by the AMCEs in Figure A4 in the Online Supporting Information. Overall, the three major Canadian parties are more similar to Republicans in the United States on AI than they are to Democrats. No Canadian party comes as close to the Democrats in support for AI.

Finally, when it comes to offshoring, Figures 4 and A5 in the Online Supporting Information show that both average support for offshoring and the effects of different attribute values on support are statistically indistinguishable for Conservative and Liberal voters. NDP voters are slightly more responsive to price changes than either Liberals or Conservatives, and they show average lower levels of support for offshoring in the no change or losses scenarios, but the differences in effects are otherwise not statistically significant. Conservatives in Canada are more supportive of offshoring than Republicans in the United States, and overall all the Canadian parties are more similar to Democrats than Republicans on offshoring.¹⁶

DISCUSSION

Recent advances in generative AI are transforming labor markets, raising new questions about the societal and political consequences of these technologies. Both AI and globalization introduce a range of

¹⁴ The interaction between partisanship and factors such as education, income, and regional economic conditions, which influence individuals’ status as winners or losers from these economic shocks, remains an important avenue for future research. Due to limitations in our data, such as the absence of regional identifiers and concerns about statistical power for analyzing higher-order interactions, we did not explore these dynamics in depth here. Future studies could shed light on the conditions under which political parties might gain or lose support based on these contextual factors.

¹⁵ To increase power, we included Independents leaning toward the Democratic Party with Democrats and Independents leaning toward the Republican Party with Republicans. Results do not differ substantially when we do not do so, which we show in the Online Supporting Information (see Figure D1).

¹⁶ One could argue that the observed partisan gaps in the United States could be driven by underlying demographic differences between Republican and Democratic voters rather than partisanship itself. To address this concern, we have run regression models that include controls for age, income, gender, and education. As shown in the Online Supporting Information, even after accounting for these demographic factors, the partisan gaps in the United States persist, suggesting that the observed partisan differences are not simply a reflection of demographic differences (see Figures C1 and C2 in the Online Supporting Information).

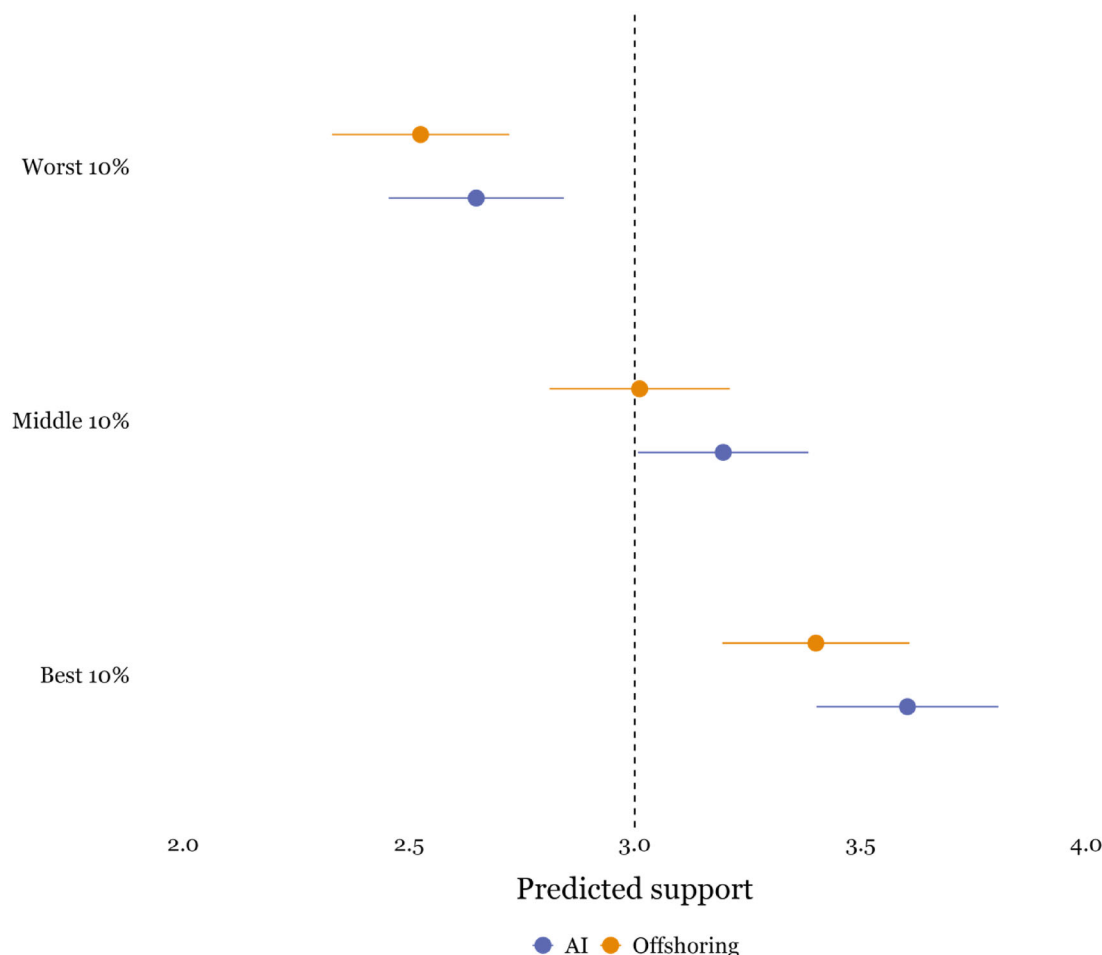


FIGURE 2 Predicted support for artificial intelligence (AI) and offshoring by worst-, same-, and best-case scenarios. *Notes:* This figure presents predicted support (1 *strongly oppose* to 5 *strongly support*) for AI and offshoring, categorized into worst-case, same-case, and best-case scenarios, along with 95% confidence intervals. These scenarios are obtained by averaging across the top 10% of best-case scenarios, the middle 10% of scenarios, and the bottom 10% of worst-case scenarios from the conjoint experiment.

economic benefits—such as job creation and lower consumer prices—but also significant costs, including job displacement and wage stagnation. These transformations are multidimensional in nature, as they affect employment, prices, and productivity simultaneously, forcing individuals to navigate complex trade-offs that shape both public opinion and political strategies. Negative portrayals of globalization, coupled with a limited understanding of the multidimensional trade-offs involved, have often shaped public opposition toward economic openness, fueling support for protectionist policies. A critical question for future research is whether AI will follow a similar trajectory and which political groups may benefit from its politicization.

Using a preregistered conjoint experiment with approximately 6,000 respondents across Canada and the United States, we examined the microfoundations of public opinion toward AI and offshoring. Our approach departs from the literature by simultaneously considering employment and price effects,

capturing how individuals respond as both workers and consumers when faced with these economic disruptions. This multidimensional framework enables us to better understand how the public evaluates the trade-offs associated with AI and offshoring.

Our findings confirm a general preference for AI over offshoring, particularly among US Democrats, whose optimism persists despite potential job losses. In contrast, Republicans and Canadians show more varied support, signaling that AI's immunity to opposition may be temporary and conditional on future political framing. For offshoring, Democrats maintain consistent levels of support, although lower than for AI. Canadian voters mirror Democrats' cautious optimism, without significant partisan differences. Republicans, while showing increased support in the face of beneficial outcomes, never fully embrace offshoring, indicating a more skeptical stance.

A consistent result is the gap in support between AI and offshoring. While both economic shocks involve

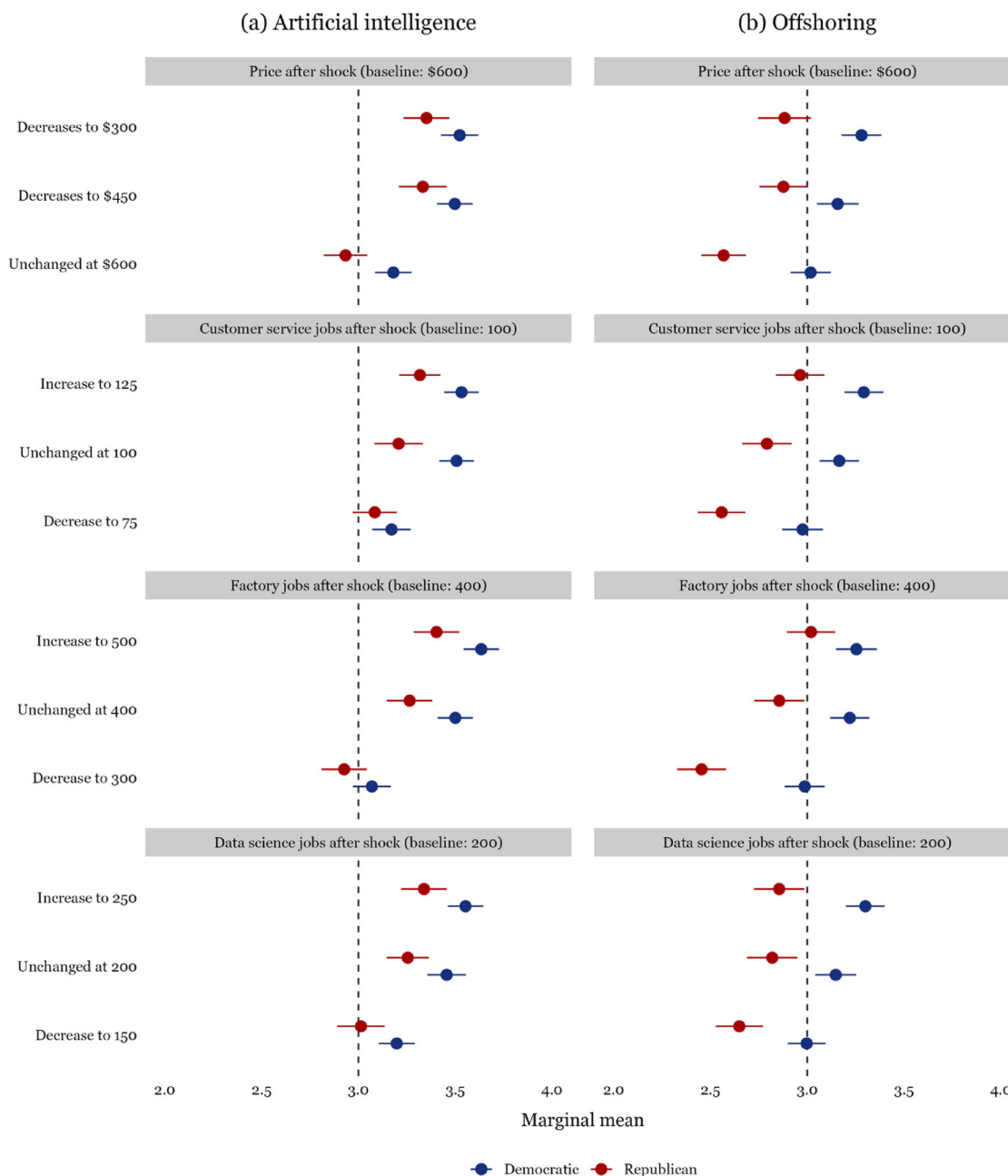


FIGURE 3 Marginal means (MMs) of support for artificial intelligence (AI) and offshoring by party in the United States. *Notes:* This figure displays MMs of support (1 *strongly oppose* to 5 *strongly support*) for AI and offshoring by respondents who identify respectively with the Democratic and Republican parties, along with 95% confidence intervals. The MMs illustrate the average outcome for each specific level of a conjoint attribute, averaging across all other attributes. Baselines represent attribute values before the economic shock.

complex trade-offs, globalization has been framed as a foreign threat, while AI is often perceived as a domestic innovation. This difference in framing likely contributes to the stronger negative responses to offshoring, which is tied to foreign competition, whereas AI remains relatively insulated from such concerns (Chaudoin & Mangini, 2024). As prior studies suggest, job losses attributed to trade tend to elicit stronger emotional responses, as they threaten national in-

groups, whereas job losses from technological change do not provoke the same level of nationalist sentiment (Mutz, 2021). Additionally, AI has not yet been politicized to the same extent as offshoring, with its economic consequences only beginning to emerge (Gallego & Kurer, 2022). This emerging status likely contributes to more favorable or neutral public attitudes toward AI, while offshoring is weighed down by a longer history of disruption and job loss.

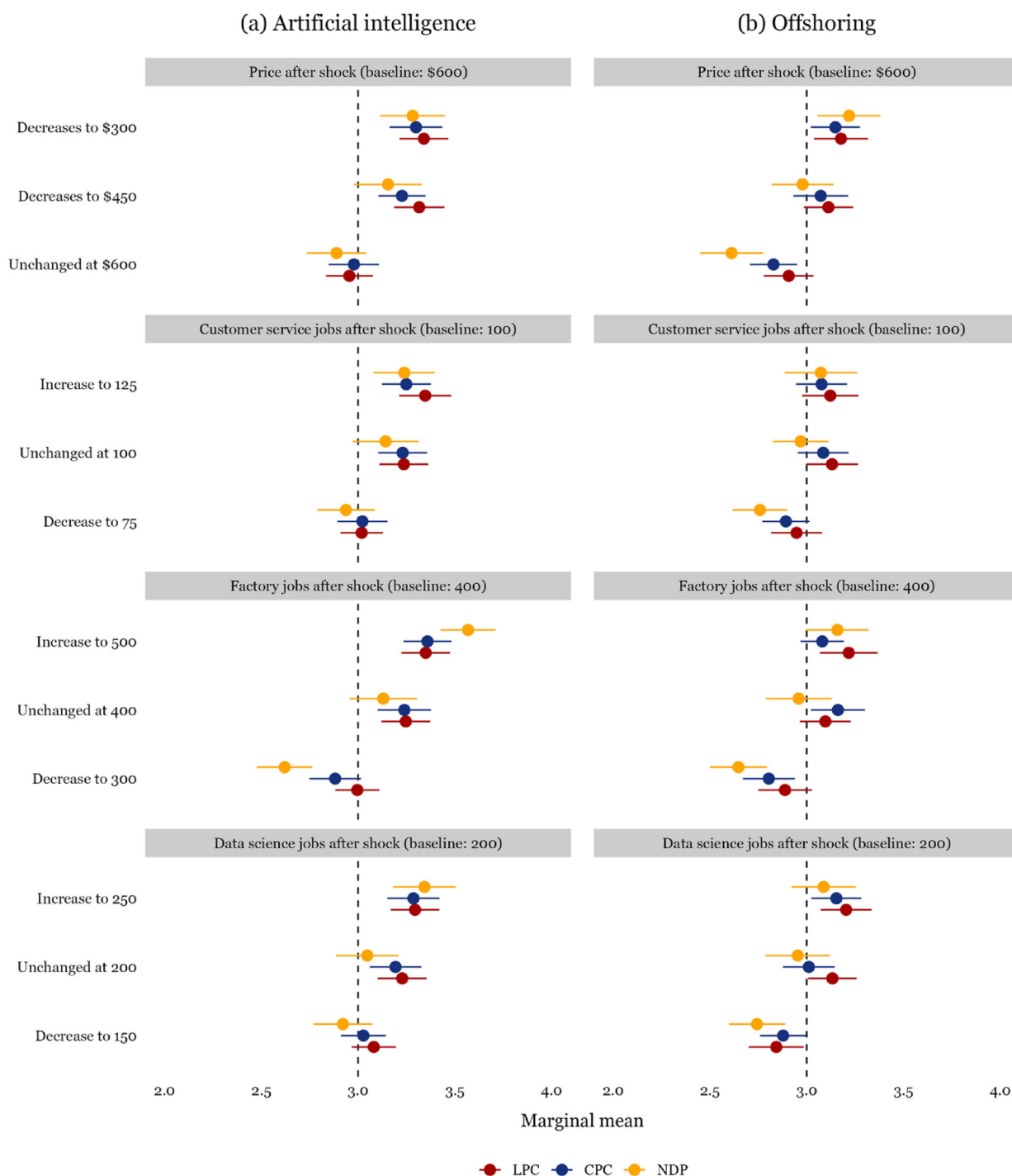


FIGURE 4 Marginal means (MMs) of support for artificial intelligence (AI) and offshoring by party in Canada. *Notes:* This figure displays MMs of support (1 *strongly oppose* to 5 *strongly support*) for AI and offshoring by respondents who identify with the Liberal Party of Canada, the Conservative Party of Canada, and the New Democratic Party, along with 95% confidence intervals. The MMs illustrate the average outcome for each specific level of a conjoint attribute, averaging across all other attributes. Baselines represent attribute values before the economic shock.

Price changes and employment shifts in both AI and offshoring scenarios play a significant role in shaping public opinion. Across political and national lines, price changes are often as influential, if not more so, than employment fluctuations. The significant impact

of price changes observed in our study highlights a critical aspect often overlooked in public discourse and policy debates. While job losses and employment shifts are undeniably crucial and emotionally charged issues, the direct and immediate benefits of lower

prices on consumer goods resonate broadly across diverse demographic groups. Individuals may prioritize their roles as consumers over their roles as workers when evaluating economic changes. Policymakers and politicians should therefore not underestimate the power of consumer interests in shaping public opinion: Addressing consumer concerns and highlighting positive price impacts could mitigate opposition to economic transformations.

These findings are especially relevant during the current inflationary period in the United States and Canada, where rising prices put direct pressure on purchasing power. As the cost of living increases, respondents may be more attuned to price changes, viewing them as more immediate and personally relevant compared to job gains or losses. Although our data were collected during a period of heightened inflation in 2023, similar patterns have emerged in other contexts (Magistro et al., 2024; Naoi & Kume, 2015). While our conjoint experiment reveals sensitivity to both employment and price changes, the mechanisms that drive the relative weight individuals place on these dimensions remain unexplored. We suggest that political framing plays a key role in shaping public attitudes, but broader macroeconomic conditions, such as inflation or unemployment, along with personal economic circumstances, may also significantly influence these preferences. Future research could further explore how economic conditions and political framing interact to shape whether individuals prioritize their roles as consumers or workers in response to these shocks.

These insights imply that political actors can sway public opinion by focusing attention on certain aspects of economic shocks, such as the risks of job displacement versus the opportunities for productivity gains and new employment in emerging sectors. By selectively highlighting certain features of AI and offshoring, politicians can influence public perception, potentially steering the narrative toward either opposition or support. This approach could resonate strongly with specific voter demographics, including right-wing voters in the United States and a broader spectrum in Canada, while also contributing to an emerging partisan divide around AI in the United States, with Democrats consistently showing greater openness to technological advances. If the current trajectory of winners versus losers from technology and AI persists, and if those most negatively affected fail to be compensated, the partisan gap may widen, increasing political polarization.

In light of our findings, it is evident that policymakers and political parties will play a crucial role in shaping public perceptions of AI. While AI holds significant potential for economic growth and productivity gains, concerns over job displacement and inequality remain central to ongoing discussions. Left unchecked, AI could exacerbate these inequalities and

further concentrate power among a small number of dominant firms (Acemoglu & Johnson, 2023). This has sparked debates around the need for stronger government oversight and the steering of AI's development to ensure more equitable outcomes. Just as globalization failed to adequately compensate those negatively impacted (Rodrik, 2018), AI risks deepening political polarization and empowering parties that challenge the current economic order if the losers of this technological shift are ignored.

Our findings already reveal partisan divides in support for AI. While public opinion does not always translate directly into policies, it can shape party strategies. Should AI become politicized, we may see different policy approaches reflecting these divides. As shown in the Online Supporting Information (Figures G1 and G2), both in the United States and Canada, left- and center-left partisans (Democrats, Liberals, NDP) are more likely to favor social investment, social spending, and regulation in response to AI than right-wing voters. Conversely, right-leaning partisans (Republicans and Conservatives) show relatively greater support for protectionist policies, such as trade and immigration restrictions, compared to left-wing respondents. This suggests that AI may be framed by these parties as a force that exacerbates economic competition with foreign countries, further deepening these divides.

While it remains to be seen how AI will be framed and which political actors will capitalize on these narratives, we identify a potential for opposition, suggesting that AI is not immune to political backlash. Addressing this challenge requires a concerted effort to provide comprehensive information and implement policies to mitigate the adverse effects on vulnerable populations, fostering a more inclusive approach to navigating AI's social and economic implications.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

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